

Discovery Notes

Problem statement

JusticeLensUK is an open justice and legal education organisation focused on making the justice system more transparent and understandable. The organisation aims to educate local journalists, teachers and charities on legal issues, including cases that may affect their work. Within the organisation, the Case Desk is responsible for monitoring official court judgments published through the National Archives' Find Case Law service and producing briefings on cases relevant to its partners. Our primary stakeholder, Ben, is a part of the Case Desk team.

Despite significant growth, the Case Desk's processes have remained informal and have not scaled accordingly. Team members currently spend entire days working across documents, spreadsheets, browser tabs and staff memory. This fragmented method of working has contributed to inconsistent selection of relevant cases and reduced visibility of previous decisions, which has affected the quality and integrity of the organisation's work.

Existing solution

The Case Desk currently relies on a largely manual process to identify, assess and summarise relevant court judgments. Team members periodically check Find Case Law for newly published judgments within current priority areas, skim individual judgments to assess their potential relevance, and note their justification in selecting or not selecting a judgment in spreadsheets.

Judgments which are considered relevant are selected for more detailed reading, from which key information is extracted and a briefing is drafted. The briefing is subsequently reviewed for legal accuracy by a senior reviewer and upon approval, adapted for its intended audience.

The current process relies heavily on individual judgment, staff knowledge and fragmented information held across spreadsheets, documents and direct communications. The rationale behind relevance decisions is not consistently recorded. This limits traceability and has made information on case progression increasingly difficult to manage as the organisation has grown and onboarded more partners.

Solution scope

The project solution's focus is on improving the Case Desk's process for identifying, assessing, tracking and producing briefings for relevant court judgments.

In scope:

- Monitoring and retrieval of newly published court judgments from the Find Case Law service
- Initial assessment of judgments against defined relevance criteria and priority areas
- Traceable, detailed record of all decisions throughout the process
- Extraction of key information from relevant judgments
- Generation of case briefings
- Human review and approval of AI-generated outputs

May be in scope:

- Manual human modifications to AI outputs
- Generation of briefing packs that combine multiple briefings
- Reporting tools to make management of performance easier
- Adaptation of briefings for specified target audiences
- Monitoring and processing updates to published court judgments

Out of scope:

- Modification of the original source judgment
- Integration of the client's Identity and Access Management system
- Generation of legal advice
- Generation and publication of newsletters and email digests
- Assessment of legal sources outside the National Archives

Discovery questions

These are the questions asked in the initial stakeholder interview as part of discovery - facts and figures gleaned from these take precedence over the project brief.

On the stakeholder

- Of these audience types: journalist; legal education charity; advice organisation; student group; campaign group (or any others), which do you already serve, even informally? 

On the current process

- How does the current process work and who does it? Could you give a step-by-step overview of it? ✓
- What about the current process is time-consuming? ✓
 - Hours, people needed, money? ✓
- Do you have baseline operational metrics for us?
 - It will allow us to identify the biggest pain points in the current process the solution can solve for you
- Walk me through, step by step, how you currently find and select judgments to write about – where do you look, how often, who decides? ✓
- What's your current process, if any, for checking reporting restrictions or anonymity orders before you write about a case? How else do you consider sensitivity?

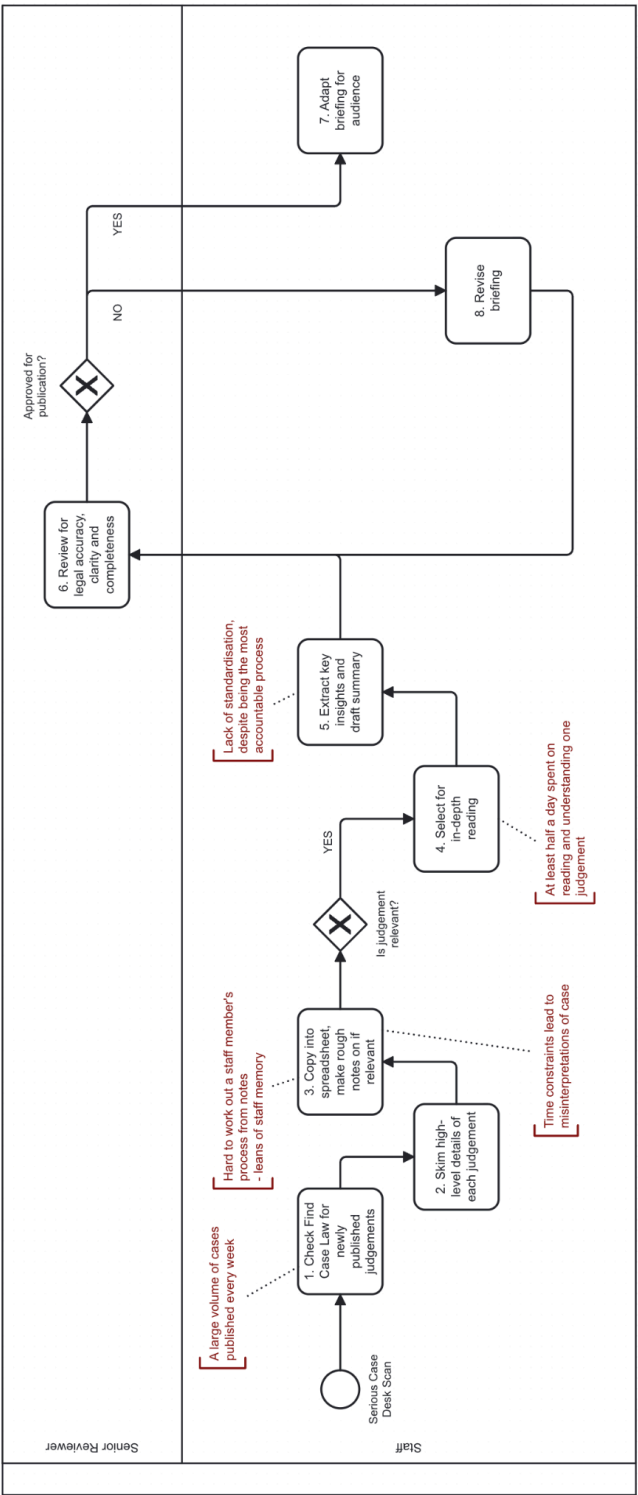
On the desired solution

- What do you want the solution to do for you? ✓
- What do you want out of the dashboard? ✓
 - We could implement a website with a view of cases that have been processed by the AI agent
- Would a narrower but well-covered case type (construction, IP, tax, immigration) be an acceptable MVP scope, even if less "human interest," if it means better data quality? ✓
- Where's the line for you between "helpful explanation" and "legal advice" – existing guidance, or a judgement call each time? ✓
- Have you applied for, or considered needing, the **Open Justice Licence's** computational analysis permission – and can you start that application this week regardless of what we build? ✓

On data points

- What factors determine what matters to the different stakeholder audiences?
 - An idea we have is to apply a rubric system for the stakeholders and scale them differently across them - allow stakeholders to scale it themselves - out of scope
- What information does a client actually need from a case – what makes a briefing useful to them versus just accurate? Will this be different for each stakeholder?

As-Is process map



Pain point	Explanation	Solution opportunity
A large volume of cases published every week	Up to 30 cases are published every day. The Case Desk team works 3 times a week, which means they regularly deal with a backlog of work.	A system which monitors the National Archives website and automatically ingests judgments as they are published
Hard to work out a staff member's process from notes – relies on staff memory	Staff carries out their work across different documents and spreadsheets, which means their work is logged heterogenously. If a staff member is out-of-office, it is difficult to take over their progress with a case.	A centralised log which captures every decision made during the process, so it is easy for a different staff member to reconstruct the progress made with a case.
Time constraints lead to misinterpretations of a case	Limited time means that staff can skim document details, which leads to inaccurate notes on why a case is relevant.	A process which utilises the same level of detail extraction across every judgment - means the time taken to process a judgment must decrease to accommodate this.
At least half a day spent reading and understand one judgment	Due to their specialist language in which legal publications are written, reading and extracting key points without missing details is a time- and effort-intensive process.	A document processing system that uses a glossary to understand and interpret terms correctly as part of its analysis.
Lack of standardisations, despite being the most accountable process	Staff members write briefings with varying structures from how they choose to lay out the details of a case. If a briefing changes hands, there is an extra step taken to consolidate differing writing styles.	A structured template that defines aspects of a judgment (parties, key quotes, outcome, etc...) to capture for every judgment.